the Afghan nobility who had stood with the British, especially the more Anglophile Qizilbash, who now had little option but hastily to pack up and follow their retreating allies; the long lines of maimed and crippled sepoys who had been left to their fate on the 1842 retreat by Elphinstone's officers, and many of whom were now gangrenous amputees who had to be carried home in swaying dhoolies and camel panniers; the 500 destitute Hindu families who had been left both ruined and homeless by the rape and destruction of their quarter in Kabul; and, bringing up the rear, the surviving members of the Sadozai dynasty and the harems of Shahs Shuja, Zaman and Fatteh Jang, all of whose hopes of recovering their Kingdom had been thwarted by the incompetence and unpopularity of the British occupation, and who now again faced an uncertain future in a foreign land. As Mohammad Husain Herati wrote in conclusion at the end of his postscript to the *Waqi'at-i-Shah Shuja*: 'Thus did the English accomplish the destruction of the Afghan royal house of Sadozai.'[107]

For even as Pollock was marching his weary troops back along the skeleton-strewn Via Dolorosa of the Khord Kabul, past the sad detritus of Elphinstone's army – 'gloves and socks, sepoys' hair combs, broken china all serving to remind us of the misery and humiliation of our troops', and with the wheels of the horse artillery crushing the skulls of the fallen troops – news arrived that Ellenborough had presided over one last betrayal of the dynasty in whose name the British had invaded Afghanistan.[108] Two weeks earlier, on 1 October, the Governor General had issued from Simla a Proclamation which formally distanced the British government from the Sadozais. It did this on the entirely spurious grounds that Shah Shuja's actions had 'brought into question his fidelity to the government by which he was restored'. This was a straightforward lie: whatever his many failings, Shuja remained strikingly faithful to the British, even after they had single-handedly torn up their treaty with him and left him to his fate in December 1841. From now on, continued Ellenborough, 'the Governor General will leave it to the Afghans themselves to create a government amidst the anarchy which is the consequence of their crimes'. The Proclamation ended with a suitably Orwellian flourish: 'To force a sovereign upon a reluctant people would be as inconsistent with the policy as it is with the principles of the British government. The Governor General will willingly recognise any government approved by the Afghans